



MIDDLESEX Community College

Tools and Technologies for Tech Writers 2025

Week 11

Sample Bookmap

Middlesex Community College 2025

This document was prepared as an assignment for the Middlesex Community College Tools and Technologies for Technical Writers class, Winter semester 2025.

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The name is defined by the value of the author key defined in your bookmap. I set them up to be your name.

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An All About DITA Topic for Roberta Roffo

This is a sample topic. It is in your homework folder and is not shared.

This is Bobbi's first paragraph in practicing the DITA structure using the Oxygen XML Editor.

I'm following the clear and detailed instructions in the Course's Homework Helpers, pages 106-123. There are many more step-by-step details and screenshots here than in the regular Week 11 & 12 DITA explanation and Homework directions from this week's Homework folder, which is about 24 pages. Both documents cover basically similar topics, but I'll be looking at these two helpful documents to see more differences.

Ok, continuing in Homework Helpers pg. 111, I'm going to add an unordered, bulleted list to the DITA file. I will use the tag. The document states that each bullet in the list is identified as an tag.

- Here is my first bullet in my unordered list.
- I do not know why Oxygen added the above arrow or tag that says ul id="ul_oys_zjs_x2c".
- I do not see that in Zoe's example in Homework Helpers.
- Hopefully I will learn that.
- I can figure the first part means unordered list and Oxygen, but what would zjs and x2c mean?
- I do not know.
- But anyway, I have created my first unordered list. DONE.

Does this SAVE automatically? I'll do File--Save in case it doesn't.

Next, I will add an ordered list to the DITA file. These are numbered lists or ABC lists. The tag that defines an ordered list is the tag. **Zoe, I see a TYPO on pg. 112! It states the tag that defines an UNORDERED list is the , and it should say ...defines an ordered list.**

1. Ok, the ol element was added and it automatically added this li element.
2. It is difficult to see the difference between the letter "l" and the number "1" in the above sentence. Anyway, here is number two of my list.
3. Here is number three and all we do is press Enter twice within this paragraph and we have the next number.
4. Here is number 4. Now, I wonder, does this ol also work for letters ABC and abc?
5. Ok, I made my Ordered List 1-5. DONE! Now, on to insert an external link in the DITA file.

You often need to reference external websites when writing.

These instructions are how to link to an external web site. Links are made using the <xref> tag. Links (the <xref> tag) need to be inside of a "block" tag, such as a

or

. They are a type
of inline tag.

1. Add a paragraph where you want to insert your link and then place your cursor.
2. Add an element, choosing the web link type. Tools

<

Ok, I inserted an External link. DONE. Now, I will insert a link to another topic.

Internal links are also made using the <xref> element. You need to set the @href attribute to the path and name of the DITA topic. OxygenXML has a great shortcut.

1. In the topic, add a paragraph with text.
2. In the DITA Maps Manager, right-click the topic you want to link to and select Copy.
3. In the Author view, place your cursor where you want to insert your link.
4. Paste in the link using CTRL + V.

A properly formatted link to the topic you selected is entered.

Here is my new paragraph with text. Now I will R-C in DITA Maps Manager the topic I want to link to, and select Copy. Zoe's example shows to choose Example Task Topic. Ok.

[Example Task Topic](#) on page 8Ok, I did that task!

I did not know how to select the Author view, but finally I saw, way below here, the 3 choices: text, grid, author, and Author is the only one highlighted, so I am already in Author view. I'll try the other views, just to see them. Ok, I can see the cascading more clearly in the Text view. The Grid view is not helpful for this document.

NEXT: Add a table to the DITA file. Tables are very useful for displaying data, but can be complicated. In DITA, you can choose between a <table> or a <simple table>.

A table in DITA is a CALS style table. You can do all sorts of complicated shading, borders, row and column spanning. The <simple table> has fewer features, but is simpler to implement. There are many different ways to create a table that enable you to build very complex tables with merged cells, different sections of the table, etc. This example only shows the bare minimum required to make a table. Also, OxygenXML has decent table tools. Have your cursor where you want to insert the table. Insert a <simple table> . The Insert Table dialog box opens. Ok, those instructions were straightforward.

1st Cousins	2nd Cousins	Siblings
<i>Cheryl</i>	David	Bill
Marcia	Donny	Karen
<u>Wendy</u>	Scott	Jack
Sue	Mark	Laura

TABLE DONE! And I did see how to do italic, Bold, underline and subscript and superscript formatting by highlighting and selecting from a pop-up. Ok.

Only two items left to do to meet the minimum. I will get the minimum done tonight and then try to do Recommended and Extra Credit next time.

1. Inline formatting – that's easy. And....
2. Insert an image in the DITA file.
 - a. Oh! it does do Letters in lists. It's cascaded. OK. I don't need this now; I was just trying to get my number 2. Press Enter twice to get the next number.

b. oops, I got the next letter.

Add inline formatting to the DITA file

Inline formatting in DITA is done with additional tagging.

You have a paragraph in your DITA file.

For inline formatting, DITA relies on semantic tagging. This means that there are many elements that identify what the content of the element is. It is up to the transform what that looks like.

The automation I have configured has formatting for the following THIRTEEN semantic tags:

- `apiname`
- `cite`
- `cmdname`
- `codeph`
- `filepath`
- `“q”` (quote)
- `term`
- **`uicontrol`**
- `userinput`
- `varname`
- **`wintitle`**
- `@@xmlatt`
- `<<xmlelement>>`

1. Add text to your topic.
2. Select the text you want to add formatting to. Ok, I followed the instructions and it changed the typed formatting of this line to the font used in filepaths. Ok. This worked, but it is not what I expected. I thought it would have bold, italics. I will try some of the other 13 elements that Zoe selected for us.
3. Press Enter and select the element you want to wrap the content with.
Notice that the option says Surround with.
4. Press Enter to add the formatting.

You now have inline formatting marked.

Insert. Ok, I figured out 12 of the 13 semantic elements. It would not allow the quote element. Need to research that. I also figured out italic, bold, underline, subscript and superscript. Great! Only the Image left, for the Bare minimum.

Insert an image in the DITA file

Images in DITA are inserted by reference.

You need to have a web-friendly image in your folder in `mcc_tools_tech\Week11-DITA`

\\Homework\\YourName. For example, you can reference a JPG, GIF, or PNG file.

You can also use a relative path from the HTML file to where the image is. If you have already added an image for another homework assignment, you could reference it. However, that requires that you understand how relative paths work. If you're not ready for that yet, just make sure your image is in your `mcc_tools_tech\\Week11-DITA\\Homework\\YourName` folder. Ok, I need to go and do that. Ok, done.

I want to insert my images HERE. Hmm, dialog box did not open. Let me try that again.



Figure 1: Insert Image

COOL! I saw the preview of the image and also the image magically appeared here! Ok, I have now completed all of the minimum HW Weeks 11-12 requirements. This took about 3 hours from reading the pdf and homework helpers and online advice, and then following the homework helpers procedures. I will submit this for now, but given time, I will also try the Recommended and Extra Credit challenges. I do enjoy basic coding, and I think I can be pretty good at it. I had done a little before as a technology teacher, but it was quite a few years ago. That's it for now! File SAVE is greyed out. I already saved, but I like to save a couple of times. I'll see if now I can save, since I made this minor change, typing these couple of sentences. Yes, it's going to let me SAVE; I see it is no longer greyed out. Probably I can only save once and I have to trust it!

Example Concept File

An example DITA topic of type concept. This is a shared topic.

Concepts should describe things. All the background information about the thing.

Concepts are not overly structured.

Example Task Topic

A DITA topic of type task. This is a shared topic. Task topics are the most structured.

This is the `<prereq>` where you list the prerequisites for this task. This section is optional.

This is the `<context>` where you can provide a bit of background of things you should know before performing the task.

Some people consider this a "mini concept". If you realize you need a bit of lead in, but not enough for a stand alone topic, use the `<context>` in the task topic instead of a stand alone concept topic. This section is optional.

1. This is a `<step>` in a task topic. It is part of the `<steps>` element. You can use `<steps>` for numbered steps or `<steps-unordered>` for a non-numbered (usually bulleted) steps.
2. These are the heart and soul of task topic.

There are many additional special elements that can be used in a step to provide more information.

3. Both the `<steps>` and `<steps-unordered>` elements are optional.

That's correct, you can have a task with no procedure.

This is the `<result>` which lets you explain what happens after you complete the steps. This element is optional.

This is `<tasktroubleshooting>` where you can provide troubleshooting information for the entire task.

Not to be confused with `<steptroubleshooting>` which can be used for troubleshooting information for specific steps.

This element is optional.

This is an `<example>` you can use to provide an example for the entire task. This is not to be confused with the `<stepxmp>` which can provide a quick example for a specific step.

This element is optional.

This is the `<postreq>` where you describe what to do after completing the procedure.

This element is optional.

That's correct, all of these elements are optional. It is possible to have a valid task topic with only a `<title>` and `<shortdesc>`. However, the order of these main elements is not optional. For example, you cannot switch the order of the `<context>` and `<prereq>` without a specialization.

Example Reference Topic

This is a DITA topic of type reference. This is a shared topic.

In general, a reference topic is used for things you look up. If you want to put it in a table, it probably should be a reference topic.

Reference topics can contain:

<section>	Generic text space.
<example>	Generic text but the intention is to hold some sort of example.
<properties>	A special list/table for properties and definitions.
<refsyn>	Syntax reference. Great for APIs.
<simpletable> or <table>	You can have a table.